Kythoria: A Documentary of the Reclaimed Lands

SECTION 1: THE WORLD OF AETRIS

1.1 The Planet

The world is called **Aetris** -- an ancient name that carries within it echoes of both "aeon" and "triad," a linguistic fossil from a time so distant that even the oldest records do not reach it. The name is fitting, for the number three recurs throughout the world's deepest truths: three known continents, three eras of recorded history, three capital cities of the Last Stand, and three forms of magic that shape the lives of all who dwell upon it.

Aetris is known to contain **three continents**. The campaign of mortal civilization unfolds primarily upon **Kythoria**, the vast landmass that stretches from frozen northern reaches to subtropical southern shores. The other two continents exist beyond the known maps -- distant lands that sailors whisper about in portside taverns, scarcely known to the peoples of Kythoria, their names and natures left to the realm of rumor and speculation.

1.2 The Planes Beyond

Beyond the material world that mortals call home, other planes of reality are known to exist. The **Inner Planes** are realms of raw elemental force -- Fire, Water, Earth, and Air -- the primordial building blocks that underpin all physical existence. The **Outer Planes** are the domains of the gods and other powerful beings, distant realms where the nature of consciousness and morality is said to be tested and shaped.

The **Feywild** and **Shadowfell** are known as realms of fey and shadow, places that mirror the material world in strange and distorted ways. The **Astral Plane** is the connective fabric that ties all planes together, a silvery void through which planar travel is possible. The **Ethereal Plane** is a misty, permeable realm that overlaps the material world, visible only to those with the right sight or the right magic.

1.3 Ley Lines

The world is crisscrossed by invisible highways of concentrated magical energy known as **ley lines**. These are not uniform in their distribution; rather, arcane energy flows along paths of least resistance, gathering in currents that those attuned to magic can sense and follow. Where ley lines converge, magic is easier to channel and more powerful. The capital city of **Weaveheart** is built upon one such convergence -- the greatest known on the continent -- and this fact has shaped its entire destiny.

SECTION 2: THE CONTINENT OF KYTWORIA

2.1 Climate & Regions

Kythoria spans multiple climate zones, each with its own character, its own challenges, and its own relationship to the ongoing war.

The Frozen North is a harsh, cold expanse of tundra, taiga, and snow-capped mountains. Before the invasion, hardy dwarf holds and human settlements dotted this unforgiving landscape. Today, much of the north remains under monster control. Rumors speak of sentient blizzards that seem to hunt with purpose, and of cold-adapted horrors that have made the frozen wastes their own.

The Temperate Heartlands enjoy four distinct seasons, with fertile farmlands, rolling hills, and dense forests. This is the most densely populated and safest region of the continent. It is here that the three capital cities -- **Skywatch**, **Emberforge**, and **Weaveheart** -- were founded near the center-southeast, forming the heart of mortal civilization.

The Subtropical South offers a warm climate with mild winters, long summers, and abundant rainfall. Dense jungles, mangrove swamps, and white-sand beaches define this region. It was one of the first areas fully recovered after the Last Stand, and its ports are now vital for trade.

The Eastern Coast is a vital artery for inter-continental trade and travel. Safe sea lanes connect major ports between the south, east, and northeast. Recovered early in the reconquering, the eastern coast is now a thriving network of port towns, fishing villages, and trading posts.

The Western Frontier is the contested zone that marks the boundary between reclaimed territory and monster-held lands. The terrain transitions from the temperate farmlands of the heartlands into rugged highlands, deep forests, and eventually the unknown reaches of the far west -- lands that have been under monster control for four centuries. The frontier is dotted with military outposts, forward operating bases, and fledgling settlements established by the brave or the desperate.

2.2 Territorial Reality

Approximately **two-thirds of the continent** has been reclaimed. The recovered south and east host thriving settlements, farms, and trade routes. Some part of the north and west remain contested, and approximately **one-third of the continent** remains under monster control. The reconquering continues, but the enemy has not been broken -- only pushed back.

2.3 Known Landmarks

The continent is marked by several key locations known to all. A **major forward operating base** on the western frontier serves as the Dawn Guard's command center for reconquering operations. **Two major sea ports** anchor the trade network: one in the southeast, heavily fortified and highly defensible, and another in the east, serving as a gateway for fishing, travel, and commerce.

SECTION 3: THE THREE ERAS OF HISTORY

3.1 Era of Foundation (~500+ Years Ago)

Before the monsters came, there was an age of prosperity. This was the age of the **Six Mortal Kingdoms** -- a time when each common race had its own sovereign realm, its own capital, and its own identity. Much has been lost to time; few records survive. What is known is pieced together from fragments of ancient texts, ruins, and oral traditions passed down through generations.

The **Kingdom of Drakhaven** was the Human kingdom, with its capital of the same name. It was the largest and most advanced city on the continent -- a sprawling metropolis of wide paved avenues and monumental

architecture, whose people self-appointed their city the "capital of Kythoria," a boast the other races accepted with a knowing smirk.

The **Kingdom of Elyndor** was the Elven kingdom, an ancient forest capital of arcane knowledge where elegant architecture wove through living trees and blended seamlessly with the natural landscape.

The **Kingdom of Kazadur** was the Dwarven kingdom, a mountain-forge capital carved into the living rock of the northeast. Its mines were the greatest on the continent, producing the currency metals and gemstones that fueled the entire economy.

The **Kingdom of Hearthglen** was the Halfling kingdom, an agricultural heartland of rolling green hills and golden grain fields. It was home to the royal mint, where raw metals from Kazadur were stamped into the coinage that flowed across the continent.

The **Kingdom of Everquill** was the Gnome kingdom, the paper capital of Kythoria -- a city of quills, ink, and endless writing, where the treaties, laws, maps, and histories of the mortal kingdoms were penned and preserved.

The **Kingdom of Stonefist** was the Half-Orc kingdom, a rugged fortress capital of proud warriors carved into defensible mountains, where strength and honor were the highest virtues.

The great overland trade route called **Crassian's Dust Circle** connected all six kingdoms, named after the great clouds of dust raised by caravans traversing the continent. Raw metals from Kazadur's mines were shipped to Hearthglen for minting into currency. A landmark business treaty between Hearthglen and Everquill first introduced standard currency across Kythoria -- a partnership that would shape the continent's economy for centuries to come.

Uncommon races -- Genasi, Dragonborn, and Tieflings -- had no kingdom of their own. They grouped together in large villages, communities bound by shared heritage rather than territory.

3.2 The Abominable End (~400 to ~200 Years Ago)

Approximately **400 years ago**, an ever-growing tide of monsters began appearing at the fringes of Kythoria. Their numbers were relentless; their origins were unknown. For two centuries, war plagued the continent -- a conflict that would come to be called **The Undying Scourge War**. Countless lives were lost. Civilizations crumbled.

The initial pace of conquest was ruthless and accelerated. The monster army swept across the continent, consuming territory with terrifying speed. But as time went by, the pace became slowed and sluggish, for reasons that no mortal scholar has been able to fully explain.

Five incredibly powerful beings came to be known as the **Five Monster Generals** -- the figureheads behind the dread army, each commanding legions of horrors. All six kingdoms fell. Cities were overrun. The mortal races were pushed to the brink of extinction. This era is remembered as a time of unimaginable cruelty and suffering, a time when hope itself seemed to die.

3.3 The Rise of the Mortals (~200 Years Ago to Present)

Approximately **200 years ago**, the surviving mortal races made their final stand near the center-southeast of the continent. Three capital cities were established -- **Skywatch**, **Emberforge**, and **Weaveheart** -- and

together they became known as **the Last Stand**. A magical barrier was developed in Weaveheart, powered by the ley line convergence, creating a safe haven from the monster hordes.

After the capitals were established, the mortal races formed an unprecedented alliance. Kings, archmages, high priests, ancient monster hunters, and knightly orders united under a single banner. The Alliance established the **Dawn Guard** -- the army of the First Alliance -- and together they waged a reconquering effort spanning multiple decades against the monster army.

The Dawn Guard achieved the impossible: **three of the Five Monster Generals** were defeated. The remaining two generals retreated and have not been seen since. Their whereabouts remain unknown to this day.

From the safety of the Last Stand, the mortal races organized and began pushing back. Campaigns continue to this day to reclaim the north and west. The south and east have been fully reclaimed and resettled. Yet several monster hoards and nests remain scattered throughout the reconquered lands, and no one knows what remains in the territories still under the rule of the monster army.

SECTION 4: THE THREE CAPITALS: HEART OF CIVILIZATION

4.1 Skywatch (The Lookout)

Skywatch is the highest-elevated of the three capital cities, perched on elevated terrain with panoramic views of the surrounding heartlands. It is the capital city for the **Elven people**, and its architecture reflects their grace and their connection to the open skies.

Skywatch serves as the primary scouting and observation post for the mortal races. It keeps constant watch over monster movements across the continent, relaying intelligence to the other two cities. The city's elevation provides a military advantage to the Dawn Guard, offering superiority of sight over the monster army.

The city is governed by a **King** who rules with the counsel of the **Council of Eyes** -- a meritocratic body of the most accomplished scouts, rangers, and strategists. Seats are earned through proven service, not birthright.

Notable features include the **Skywatch War College**, which trains fighters, paladins, rangers, and strategic officers; the **Guiding Hand Guild**, headquarters of the continent's premier scouting organization; the **Cartography Hall**, which houses maps, scouting reports, and intelligence archives spanning two centuries; and the **Skywatch Chorus**, a famous choir that performs at major festivals.

Skywatch is favored by those attuned to scouting, vigilance, and ranged combat.

4.2 Emberforge (The Forge)

Emberforge is an **underground city** built beneath a volcanic ash wasteland, harnessing immense geothermal heat and volcanic resources. It is the capital city for the **Dwarven people**, and its halls echo with the ring of hammers and the glow of forge-fire.

Emberforge is the **industrial heart** of the reconquering effort. It produces the weapons, armor, and equipment used by the Dawn Guard to retake their lands. The geothermal forges of Emberforge reach temperatures no surface forge can match, allowing the smithing of exceptional alloys and metals. The equipment produced here gives the technological advantage to the Dawn Guard against the monster army.

The city is governed by a **King** who rules with the counsel of the **Forgemaster's Circle** -- representing the most powerful smithing guilds, engineering houses, and industrial clans. Politics in Emberforge are shaped by production output, resource control, and the influence of its major craft families.

Notable features include the **Volcanic Forges**, geothermally-powered furnaces of unmatched temperature; the **Engineering Halls**, premier training grounds for artificers; the **Engineering Archives**, housing schematics, metallurgical treatises, and architectural plans; and the **Emberforge Opera**, a dramatic art form that combines music, precise engineering, and magical effects.

Emberforge produces weapons and armor considered the finest available, tools for farming and construction, components for arcane research, and unique alloys made possible by volcanic heat and rare ores. It is also becoming a center for monster-part crafting innovation.

4.3 Weaveheart (The Nexus)

Weaveheart is built at the convergence of **multiple ley lines**, making it the arcane and research heart of the Last Stand. It is the capital city for the **Human people**, and its towers and spires reach toward the sky, resonating with the magical energy that flows beneath its foundations.

It was here that the magical barrier was first developed and later expanded to protect all three capitals. Weaveheart remains the center of magical research, innovation, and education.

The city is governed by a **King** who rules with the counsel of the **Arcane Conclave** -- an assembly of the most powerful wizards, scholars, and arcane researchers. Weaveheart is a magocracy in practice: knowledge of the weave translates directly into political influence.

Notable features include the **Grand Athenaeum**, the largest collection of arcane texts, historical records, and pre-invasion literature on the continent; the **Weaveheart Academy of Arcane Arts**, the continent's premier magical institution; the **Magical Barrier**, a stable, reliable defensive perimeter protecting all three capitals, constantly maintained by Weaveheart's mages; and the **Weaveheart Illuminations**, magical light shows and illusions performed for entertainment.

4.4 The Magical Barrier

The magical barrier is a stable, reliable defensive perimeter capable of keeping monsters at bay. It was first developed in Weaveheart using the ley line convergence, then later expanded to create a perimeter encompassing all three capitals. The barrier has held for **two centuries** -- a constant, silent guardian that has allowed the mortal races to survive and eventually push back. Maintaining it requires constant arcane attention from Weaveheart's mages, a task that never ceases, day or night.

SECTION 5: GOVERNANCE, LAW & ORDER

5.1 The Council Accord

The **Council Accord** is the closest thing mortal civilization has to a central authority. It consists of the three kings of the capital cities -- Skywatch, Emberforge, and Weaveheart -- who convene to make decisions affecting all three cities and the broader reconquering effort.

The Accord has no fixed schedule; the kings gather frequently by tradition, and any one of them may invoke a formal council when matters arise. The structure exists by design to ensure no single point of failure -- if one city falls, the others continue.

5.2 The Survival Code

Five Articles apply across all territories, forming the foundation of law:

- **Life** -- No murder shall be tolerated.
- **Supply** -- No theft of military resources shall be permitted.
- **Allegiance** -- No treason against the mortal races shall go unpunished.
- **Barrier** -- No sabotage of defenses shall be allowed.
- **Truth** -- No false accusations shall be made.

Penalties range from labor to exile to execution. Beyond the Code, each settlement governs itself through a patchwork of local customs, creating variance in enforcement across the land.

5.3 The Guild System

The major guilds of Kythoria provide training, representation, and a social safety net for their members. The **Thalkis Ember** guild governs metalworkers and artisans. The **Guiding Hand** manages intelligence and frontier navigation. The **Weaveheart Academy of Arcane Arts** oversees arcane research and education. The **Sons of Crassian** handle commerce and trade. The **Drakh Ix'thar** coordinates monster hunting and ruin delving.

Each guild serves as more than a trade association -- it is a community, a training ground, and a source of identity for its members.

5.4 Political Landscape

The political structures of Kythoria are young, approximately two centuries old, and still crystallizing. On the **frontier**, leadership is determined by the **3S's Merit-based system** -- those who demonstrate strength, strategy, and soul rise to lead. In the **heartland**, traditional authorities hold sway: wealthy families, established guilds, and old names that carry weight from before the invasion.

Authority varies significantly by settlement, and tensions exist between the interests of the capitals and the needs of the frontier.

5.5 A Militarized People

Every able-bodied citizen is expected to contribute to the reconquering in some form. The Dawn Guard, as the unified army, functions as a major military force that contracts local mercenary companies for specific operations, injecting significant coin into local economies.

SECTION 6: THE PANTHEON: GODS OF KYTWORIA

6.1 The Divine Order

The mortal races worship a pantheon of **ten gods**. According to church doctrine, each god created a specific mortal race and governs specific domains of existence. The gods are not distant abstractions -- they are active presences in daily life, their names invoked in prayer, their festivals marking the passage of time.

6.2 The Seven Recognized Gods

Seven of the ten gods are openly worshipped within Last Stand territories. Their churches are recognized members of the Ecumenical Council, and their clergy walk freely among the people.

#	God	Domains	Church	Role
1	**Kaelthor**	Nature, Tempest	Circle of the Wild	Druids, weather-watchers, frontier folk
2	**Aurelius**	Wisdom, Justice	Order of the Scales	Judges, scholars, lawkeepers
3	**Vesper**	Peace, Twilight	Vigil of the Dusk	Diplomats, threshold guardians, funeral rites
4	**Aloria**	Light, Life	Order of the Dawn	Healers, protectors, midwives
5	**Tyra**	Hunt, Nature	Pack of Tyra	Hunters, survivalists, trackers
6	**Thalkis**	Forge, Arcana	Guild of the Spark	Smiths, enchanters, artificers
7	**Crassian**	Wealth, Fortune	Order of the Currency	Merchants, bankers, traders

6.3 The Three Banned Gods

Three gods are publicly blamed for orchestrating the monster invasion. Their churches are banned from operating openly within Last Stand territories.

#	God	Domains	Church	Why Banned
8	**Raven Queen**	Death, Grave	Order of the Raven	Blamed for monster invasion
9	**Vorn**	War, Conquest	Iron Host	Blamed for monster invasion
10	**Lolth**	Trickery, War	Coven of the Spider	Blamed for monster invasion

6.4 The Creation Myth

The order in which the gods created the world, according to church teaching, is as follows:

1. **Kaelthor** shaped the world, planes, and nature from chaos (Month 1)
2. **Aurelius** imposed laws and order upon nature (Month 2)
3. **Vesper** introduced peace, harmony, and boundaries between states (Month 3)
4. **Aloria** brought light and reproduction (Month 4)
5. **Tyra** instilled hunger and survival instinct (Month 5)
6. **Raven Queen** completed the cycle with death and mourning (Month 6)
7. **Thalkis** taught forge and arcane knowledge (Month 7)
8. **Crassian** introduced currency and trade (Month 8)
9. **Vorn** granted the ability to wage war and conquer (Month 9)
10. **Lolth** provided wit and cunning to avoid conflict (Month 10)

6.5 Individual God Profiles

Kaelthor is the god of the untamed world: wilderness, storms, beasts, and raw natural forces. His personality is described as wild, unpredictable, and indifferent to mortal concerns. Worship takes place in shrines in wild

places rather than cities; the world itself is considered the only true temple. His followers are druids, rangers, sailors, and farmers.

Aurelius is the god of truth, learning, law, and fair judgment. Measured, calm, and deliberate, he represents justice that requires wisdom, not merely law. His temples double as courts, libraries, and academies. His followers are judges, scholars, diplomats, and lawkeepers.

Vesper is the god of serenity, boundaries, transitions, and the quiet spaces between. Serene, patient, and diplomatic, Vesper values understanding over conflict. Temples are quiet sanctuaries of peace where mediators resolve conflicts. Followers include diplomats, hospice workers, and gatekeepers.

Aloria is the benevolent face of the pantheon: healing, compassion, radiance, the life-giving sun. Warm, nurturing, and protective of mortals, she is the most beloved and trusted god. Temples exist in all settlements. Her followers are healers, midwives, protectors, and common folk.

Tyra is the god of the hunt, tracking, predator-prey balance, and survival. Patient, sharp, and instinctual, Tyra respects the hunt as a sacred cycle. Shrines are found in the deep wilderness. Followers are rangers, hunters, trackers, and scouts.

Thalkis is the god of creation through craft and magic: patron of artisans, smiths, inventors, and mages. Meticulous, creative, and patient, Thalkis values skill, dedication, and the pursuit of mastery. Temples are workshops, forges, and arcane libraries. Followers are smiths, enchanters, and artificers.

Crassian is the god of trade, commerce, prosperity, luck, and fate. Pragmatic and opportunistic, Crassian favors ambition and risk-taking. Temples double as banks and marketplaces. Followers are traders, moneylenders, gamblers, and adventurers.

The Raven Queen is the banned god of death, the grave, and the cycle of life and death. Solemn, patient, and absolute, she despises undeath. Worship is banned in Last Stand territories; the Order of the Raven operates in hidden sanctuaries. Her followers are grave wardens and memory-keepers.

Vorn is the banned god of war, battle, strategy, conquest, and the glory of victory. Bold, commanding, and relentless, Vorn sees war as the ultimate test of worth. Worship is officially banned; the Iron Host operates underground. Followers include soldiers, generals, and mercenaries who worship in secret.

Lolth, the Spider Queen, is the banned god of trickery, war, deception, and cunning. Manipulative, patient, and merciless, Lolth rewards clever schemes and punishes failure. Worship is banned, and the Coven of the Spider operates in hidden sanctuaries. Her followers are spies and assassins.

6.6 The Ecumenical Council

The **Ecumenical Council** is the interfaith governing body representing the **seven recognized churches**. It mediates disputes between faiths, coordinates major religious festivals, and ensures that worship remains organized and unified. The Council meets in a neutral hall in **Weaveheart**. The three banned churches -- the Coven of the Spider, the Order of the Raven, and the Iron Host -- are excluded from its deliberations.

6.7 Divine Conflict

The gods are understood to have rivalries, alliances, and conflicts among themselves. These divine conflicts are considered genuine by the faithful, and the three banned gods are seen as enemies of the seven

recognized gods. The tensions between them are believed to echo through the mortal world, shaping the fortunes of nations and the lives of individuals.

SECTION 7: TIME & FESTIVALS

7.1 Calendar Structure

The calendar of Kythoria is a system of 10 months, each named after a god in the order of creation. Each month has 2 weeks, and each week has 10 days, for a total of 20 days per month and **200 days per year**. The 10-day week follows a pattern of 4 work days, 2 rest days, 3 work days, and 1 rest day. The weekday names are: **Wildtide, Lawrest, Duskfall, Life-dawn, Fangrest, Gravefall, Sparktide, Cointide, Warmorn, Shadowrest**.

The calendar has existed for approximately **500 years**, established by the first mortal kingdoms soon after they organized into societies. It has been in continuous use ever since, surviving the Abominable End and the reconquering.

7.2 The Eight Festivals

Each month has its own festival, observed on the first day of the month:

Month	God	Festival	Description
1. Kaelthor	Kaelthor	Harvest Communion	Feasting and giving thanks
2. Aurelius	Aurelius	The Weighing	Legal amnesty, oath-renewal
3. Vesper	Vesper	The Dusk Chime	An hour of silence at sunset
4. Aloria	Aloria	Sunrise Rekindling	A grand illumination ceremony
5. Tyra	Tyra	The Great Hunt	A continent-wide hunting competition
6. Raven Queen	Raven Queen	The Lantern Vigil	Paper lanterns released for the dead
7. Thalkis	Thalkis	The Great Forging	A craft fair and invention exhibition
8. Crassian	Crassian	Fortune's Gamble	Markets, gambling, commerce
9. Vorn	Vorn	The Bloody Standard	War games and military parades
10. Lolth	Lolth	Night of Whispers	Shadowed deals, observed in secret

7.3 The Day of Silence

The last day of the year, Day 200, is a secular observance known as the **Day of Silence**. No work is done. No magic is cast. It is a day of quiet reflection, a time to honor the dead. It is the only day of the year not tied to any god.

SECTION 8: SOCIETY & CULTURE

8.1 Core Values

Two centuries of shared struggle have forged a distinct Kythorian identity, built on five core values:

Unity -- "Divided we fight but united we stand." Racial differences persist in traditions and cuisine, but a sense of community against a common enemy reigns supreme. No exclusion, no discrimination is tolerated. The overarching culture is shared.

Resilience -- Hardship is met with determination. Stoicism is admired; complaint is seen as weakness. People speak of problems only if they offer solutions.

Contribution -- Every citizen is expected to do their part. Laziness is heavily stigmatized.

Curiosity -- A desire to recover lost knowledge and to innovate drives progress. The world before the invasion holds secrets that could change everything.

Faith -- Religion is central to daily life. Brief prayers at household shrines are a common practice, and the gods are invoked in moments of need, gratitude, and reflection.

8.2 Living with Death

The proximity of death shapes Kythorian culture in profound ways. Grand festivals and plentiful food celebrate life in defiance of the darkness. **Memory shrines** -- small altars with candles lit for the fallen -- are maintained in homes and public squares, ensuring that the dead are never forgotten.

The frontier is viewed as both a source of fear and a source of opportunity. Fighters, adventurers, and reconquerors are seen as a heroic class that does not demand respect but earns it through their deeds.

8.3 Education

Public academies, funded by guild taxes, provide basic education from ages 6 to 12, covering reading, writing, mathematics, history, and physical training. From ages 12 to 18, children enter apprenticeship in a guild trade or military service.

Higher education is available at the **Weaveheart Academy of Arcane Arts** (for mages), the **Skywatch War College** (for military officers), and church seminaries (for clerics and paladins).

The great libraries of Kythoria are centers of learning and preservation: the **Grand Athenaeum** in Weaveheart holds arcane texts and historical records; the **Cartography Hall** in Skywatch houses maps and intelligence archives; the **Engineering Archives** in Emberforge store schematics and metallurgical treatises.

Approximately **70% of pre-invasion records** were destroyed during the Abominable End. Knowledge recovery is a respected profession, and adventurers are often contracted to retrieve texts from monster-occupied sites.

8.4 Arts & Entertainment

Music and performance flourish across the three capitals. The **Skywatch Chorus** performs at major festivals. The **Emberforge Opera** combines music, precise engineering, and magical effects. The **Weaveheart Illuminations** are magical light shows that dazzle audiences.

Literature takes the form of epic poems, practical manuals, scouting journals, and religious texts. Popular games include strategy games, riddle contests, smithing competitions, and archery tournaments.

8.5 Social Structure

Standing in Kythorian society is earned through **concrete contributions to the reconquering**: monsters slain, territory reclaimed, communities protected. There is no rigid caste system. Reputation is local -- what matters in one settlement may differ in another. Tensions exist between capital interests and frontier needs, between old pre-invasion family names and new merit earned through deeds.

SECTION 9: THE PEOPLES OF KYTWORIA

9.1 The Common Races

Humans are the most populous race of Kythoria. Created by **Aloria**, they live approximately 100 years. They are found everywhere across the continent, adaptable and ambitious, central to the reconquering effort. Humans hold significant political power through the Church of Light and Life, the most influential religious institution in the land.

Elves are long-lived and nature-attuned, created by **Kaelthor**. They live approximately 750 years. Two standard subraces exist: **High Elves**, with arcane affinity and grace, and **Wood Elves**, hardy and deeply connected to forests. Two additional elven subraces exist -- the **Drow** and the **Shadow Elves (Shadar-kai)** -- each with their own distinct origins and cultures.

Dwarves are master crafters and smiths, created by **Thalkis**. They live approximately 350 years. Dwarven smiths are central to Emberforge's industrial output, and they are prominent in the **Thalkis Ember** guild.

Halflings are known for their luck and their presence in trade and commerce. Created by **Crassian**, they live approximately 250 years. They are well-liked and trusted across Kythoria, known as the continent's perfect accountants. Their former capital, Hearthglen, housed the royal mint that produced the currency of all six kingdoms.

Dragonborn are perfect hunters with draconic heritage, created by **Tyra**. They live approximately 80 years. Their draconic ancestry grants them breath weapons and damage resistance. They are respected across Kythoria, especially on the frontier.

Gnomes are scholars and wisdom-keepers, created by **Aurelius**. They live approximately 500 years. **Forest Gnomes** live close to nature; **Rock Gnomes** are inventors and tinkerers. Both contribute to scholarship, law, and invention.

Half-Elves are the natural offspring of Elves and Humans. They live approximately 200 years. No god claims them directly. They are natural diplomats and wanderers, generally accepted across Kythoria.

Half-Orcs are the natural offspring of interbreeding. Orcs were created by **Vorn**, the banned god of war and conquest. Half-Orcs live approximately 75 years. They fought bravely in the First Alliance and helped found the Last Stand, yet they face discrimination because Vorn is a banned god. They are mistrusted in nearly every settlement, seen as brutish and prone to violence. Half-Orcs who follow Vorn must do so in secret.

Tieflings live approximately 100 years. No god claims them. They face deep prejudice as "godless" or "abandoned" by the divine, and are often the first blamed for crimes. Despite this, many have integrated into Last Stand society, proving their worth through deeds rather than divine favor.

9.2 The Uncommon Races

Genasi are beings with a connection to the Elemental Planes, created by **Vesper**. They live approximately 120 years. Four elemental subtypes exist: **Air Genasi** (connected to the sky), **Earth Genasi** (stone and soil), **Fire Genasi** (flame and heat), and **Water Genasi** (rivers and seas). They are rare but generally accepted across Kythoria, their elemental nature viewed with curiosity rather than hostility.

9.3 Races Summary

Race	God	Social Standing
Humans	Aloria	Respected; politically powerful
Elves	Kaelthor	Respected
Dwarves	Thalkis	Respected for craftsmanship
Halflings	Crassian	Well-liked and trusted
Dragonborn	Tyra	Respected, especially on frontier
Gnomes	Aurelius	Respected as scholars
Half-Elves	(none)	Generally accepted
Genasi	Vesper	Accepted, viewed with curiosity
Half-Orcs	Vorn (Orcs)	Mistrusted, discriminated against
Tieflings	(none)	Distrusted as "godless"
Drow	Lolth	Highly distrusted, few on surface
Shadow Elves	Raven Queen	Distrusted, rare visitors

SECTION 10: THE OUTSIDERS: DROW & SHADOW ELVES

10.1 The Drow

The **Drow** are an elven subrace with sunlight sensitivity, created by **Lolth, the Spider Queen**. They are known to dwell in the Underdark, a sunken forest in the south-west of the continent where a colossal Black Willow blocks all sunlight from the forest floor.

The Drow never participated in the First Alliance nor helped found the Last Stand. They held their ground in the Underdark during the monster invasion, but emerged only after the worst had passed. Today, they are viewed with deep suspicion in Last Stand territories. Few Drow walk the surface; those who do face hostility and constant scrutiny.

10.2 The Shadow Elves

The **Shadow Elves (Shadar-kai)** are an elven subrace with a profound connection to the **Shadowfell**, created by the **Raven Queen**. They are the primary worshippers of the banned goddess of death and the grave.

Little is known about them by surface-dwellers. Their connection to the Shadowfell and to death fuels prejudice against them, and Shadow Elf visitors to Last Stand cities are rare and typically watched.

SECTION 11: THE ECONOMY

11.1 Currency

The standard currency system follows familiar denominations recognized across all territories: **Copper Pieces (cp)** for everyday transactions, **Silver Pieces (sp)** for standard wages and trade, **Gold Pieces (gp)** for high-value trade and magic items, and **Platinum Pieces (pp)** for extremely rare, large-scale commerce between major guilds.

11.2 The Royal Mint

The **Royal Mint**, located in the former Kingdom of Hearthglen, is the backbone of the continental economy. Raw metals and gemstones from the northeast mining cluster are received here, refined, and stamped into standard coinage. The mint was established before the monster invasion and was one of the crown jewels of the halfling economy. After the reconquering, minting operations resumed, and the mint remains the foundation of currency across the land.

11.3 The Northeast Mining Cluster

Located in the northeast of Kythoria, the northeast mining cluster contains the greatest known mines for both precious metals and gemstones. Before the invasion, it was part of the **Kingdom of Kazadur** (the Dwarven kingdom). The cluster consists of one major settlement, **Kazadur**, and three minor ones: a logistics hub where Halflings coordinate the shipping of raw materials, a mining town focused on currency metals, and a mining town focused on gemstones. The mining towns are open to any race wanting to earn coin.

11.4 Major Industries

Mining & Prospecting -- The northeast cluster is the heart of mining operations, with additional mines in the recovered south and east.

Metalworking & Smithing -- **Emberforge** is the industrial heart of the mortal races, producing weapons, armor, tools, and arcane components. Emberforge's technology is the most advanced on the continent, and its weapons are considered the finest available.

Agriculture -- Staple crops include grains (wheat, barley, oats), rice, exotic fruits, and spices. Livestock includes cattle, sheep, and poultry. Food security is a strategic priority, and the granaries of the three capitals maintain enough reserves to survive a siege of several years. The forests in and surrounding the Last Stand are exceptionally fertile.

Arcane Industry -- **House Thormvuld**, a dwarven arcane engineering family, is the most prominent magical item producer on the continent. They originate from the northeast region and own a dedicated settlement for their workshops. Recently, they built the floating estate **Seidga'ard**. **Weaveheart** also produces high-quality enchanted equipment and trains new spellcasters.

Monster Hunting -- The continent-wide **Drakh Ix'thar** is the primary controller of the monster hunting industry. Settlements, caravans, and military outposts contract the guild for monster extermination, ruin clearance, and frontier scouting. Monster parts are traded for alchemy, crafting, and arcane components.

The Military -- The **Dawn Guard** functions as a major military force, financed by the Last Stand. It contracts local mercenary companies for specific operations, injecting significant coin into local economies.

11.5 Trade Routes

Crassian's Dust Circle is an ancient overland trade route that predates the monster invasion. Originally established to connect the six pre-invasion kingdoms, it was named after the great clouds of dust raised by caravans traversing the continent. Restored during the reconquering, it now connects most major settlements and remains the primary overland trade artery.

The **Eastern Sea Route** is a series of ports along the eastern coast, connecting the southern ports to the heartlands. Ships carry goods north and south, stopping at waypoint towns. It is safer than land travel and handles the bulk of bulk trade.

11.6 Exports & Challenges

Major exports include exotic fruits, spices, timber, and rare herbs from the south; precious metals, gemstones, and minted currency from the northeast; weapons, armor, and industrial goods from Emberforge; and enchanted items and magical components from Weaveheart.

The economy faces persistent challenges: resource scarcity, as many mines and forests remain under monster control; trade disruption from monster attacks on caravans and ships; war economy inflation, as military production consumes resources that could otherwise go to civilian development; and a thriving black market in monster parts, illegal magical components, and contraband.

SECTION 12: MAGIC IN KYTWORIA

12.1 The Arcane Weave

The **Arcane Weave** is the permeating field of magical energy that exists across all reality. It is the source of all arcane magic. Wizards study and manipulate the Weave through formulae, gestures, and components. Sorcerers draw from it innately through bloodline or attunement. The Weave is not uniform; **ley lines** serve as concentrated highways of magical energy.

12.2 Three Paths of Magic

Public understanding recognizes three forms of magic:

Path	Source	Classes
Arcane	The Weave (studied or innate)	Wizard, Sorcerer, Bard, Artificer, Warlock
Divine	Granted by the gods through prayer	Cleric, Paladin
Primal	Drawn from nature's own absorbed energy	Druid, Ranger

12.3 Divine & Primal Magic

Divine magic is understood to be granted by the gods through prayer. Clerics and paladins channel divine favor, each god granting specific domains of magic to their faithful. The god's power is believed to flow through the cleric, shaping their spells and blessings.

Primal magic is drawn from the natural world, which is itself imbued with arcane energy. Druids attune to the cycle of life, seasons, and living things. Rangers draw from wild places and their connection to the natural world. Barbarian rage is seen as channeling primal fury, an unfiltered expression of the same natural force.

12.4 Spell Components & Ley Lines

Spellcasting requires components: **Verbal** and **Somatic** components are words and gestures that shape magical energy; **Material** components are physical items that serve as focal points, with costly components being rare and consumed in the casting.

Ley lines are invisible highways of concentrated arcane energy crisscrossing the world. Magic is easier to channel near ley line convergences, and areas far from them may feel magically impoverished. Weaveheart is built at a major convergence.

12.5 Magical Items

Enchanted weapons, armor, and tools are highly valued across Kythoria. **House Thormvuld** is the premier producer of magical items, while **Weaveheart Academy** also produces enchanted equipment. Magical items recovered from pre-invasion ruins and monster nests are highly sought after.

12.6 The Strange Crystals

Rumors, whispers, and gossip have begun circulating among the public about strange crystals of unknown origin. A heist was reportedly pulled on the Thormvuld floating estate by two coordinated parties. House Thormvuld claims nothing too valuable was stolen. Beyond this, much of the public has only heard rumors of "strange crystals" -- their nature, origin, and true significance remain unknown to the common citizen.

SECTION 13: THE CALLINGS: ADVENTURING CLASSES

13.1 The Thirteen Classes

Class	Power Source	Public Perception
Artificer	Weave manipulation through craft	Highly respected; valued in Emberforge & frontier
Barbarian	Primal fury; survival instinct	Respected warrior tradition; four great tribes
Bard	Innate arcane + Weave; expressed through art	Highly respected history-keepers and diplomats
Cleric	Divine channeling through prayer	Pillars of communities; deeply trusted
Druid	Primal attunement to nature	Respected; essential on the frontier
Fighter	Pure martial discipline	Backbone of the military; common and respected
Monk	Inner Ki discovered through meditation	Rare; viewed with curiosity and respect
Paladin	Oath to a god; power through conviction	Respected holy warriors; military arm of faith

Class	Power Source	Public Perception
Ranger	Primal attunement + martial skill	Essential for survival; deeply respected
Rogue	Skill, stealth, and cunning	Feared, distrusted, but acknowledged as essential
Sorcerer	Innate bloodline connection	Curiosity mixed with mistrust
Warlock	Pact with an external entity	Mistrust and fear-respect
Wizard	Weave study and precision	Respected in Weaveheart; scholarly elite

13.2 Where They Train

Formal institutions for training include the **Weaveheart Academy of Arcane Arts** (wizards, sorcerers, bards), the **Skywatch War College** (fighters, paladins, rangers, officers), the **Emberforge Engineering Halls** (artificers), church seminaries across all capitals (clerics, paladins), and the **Guiding Hand Guild** in Skywatch (rangers, rogues).

Informal training paths are equally common. **Apprenticeship** is the most common path, with blacksmiths teaching artificers and veterans teaching fighters. **Tribal tradition** passes down the ways of barbarians and some druids. **Self-taught** sorcerers and rogues learn through necessity. **Wandering masters** teach the rare monks and some bards. **Pact-based** warlocks receive power directly from their patrons.

13.3 The Dawn Guard's Composition

The Dawn Guard fields a diverse force: **Frontline** fighters, paladins, barbarians, and monks; **Support** clerics, druids, and rangers; and an **Arcane Corps** of wizards and artificers. Sorcerers, warlocks, and rogues are rare in the formal army.

SECTION 14: DRAKH IX'THAR: THE ADVENTURERS' GUILD

14.1 Name & Identity

Drakh Ix'thar -- "The Great Dragon Hunt" in Draconic -- is a continent-wide organization that predates the monster invasion. Its members are called **Ix'tharian** (singular: Ix'thari). The guild survived the Abominable End and was re-established during the reconquering. Its headquarters are in **Drakhaven** at the center of the continent, and chapter houses exist in every major settlement.

14.2 What the Guild Does

The guild serves as a **contract broker**, connecting parties with settlements needing monster extermination, ruin clearance, or frontier scouting. It provides **licensing and certification**, ensuring minimum competence and accountability. It functions as an **information network**, sharing intelligence about frontier conditions and monster movements. And it offers a **support system**, providing healing, equipment repair, safe lodging, and resupply to members in the field.

14.3 Ranks & Advancement

The guild does not restrict membership by class. Ranks are named in Draconic after legendary beasts, and advancement is based on successful contracts and contribution to the reconquering. The highest rank is **Drah Ix'thari** (Dragon Hunter). Higher ranks unlock access to more dangerous contracts, restricted zones, and greater guild resources.

14.4 History

The Drakh Ix'thar was founded long before the Abominable End as a guild of monster hunters serving the six kingdoms. During the invasion, its chapter houses became fortified refuges. The fall of Drakhaven in Year 134 forced the guild to suspend operations. Many of its members fought alongside the First Alliance. It was re-established during the reconquering, with its headquarters in Drakhaven restored.

14.5 Adventurers in Society

Adventurers are seen as **guardians, cleansers, and reclaimers** -- not mere mercenaries. They handle threats beyond city walls, clear ruins, and recover artifacts. The profession carries immense honor and respect. The guild's economic role is vital: clearing monster nests makes land safe for settlement, recovering treasure from pre-invasion and monster-occupied ruins brings resources back into circulation, gathering frontier intelligence supports military operations, and field-testing prototype weapons from Emberforge drives innovation.

SECTION 15: THE MONSTER THREAT

15.1 Origins & The Invasion

Approximately **400 years ago**, monsters began appearing at the fringes of Kythoria. Their origins remain **unknown** to the general public. The numbers were relentless; they pushed inward, consuming territory. For two centuries, the war known as **The Undying Scourge War** raged across the continent, driving the mortal races before them and pushing civilization to the brink of extinction.

15.2 Types of Monsters

Invasion Monsters are the diverse creatures that appeared during the Abominable End. Their forms and abilities vary across regions, and their origins remain a mystery.

Native Monsters are magical beasts that existed on Kythoria before the invasion. These include dragons, owlbears, basilisks, manticores, griffons, and similar creatures. They are not allied with the invasion forces.

Crystal-Corrupted monsters are a poorly understood phenomenon. They exhibit visible crystal growths protruding from their bodies, enhanced durability, and strange behavior that distinguishes them from others of their kind.

15.3 The Five Generals

By the time the Last Stand was founded, the monster army had consolidated under **Five Major Generals** -- the most powerful and cunning creatures to emerge from the invasion. The First Alliance achieved the impossible: they defeated **three of the Five Generals**. The remaining two generals retreated and have not been seen since. The identities of the five generals are unknown to the public.

15.4 Current State

With no new monsters arriving from unknown sources, those already on Kythoria remain devastating. The **Frozen North** is still largely monster-held. Several monster groups now seem to operate semi-independently; the unity of the monster army appears fractured. Approximately **one-third of the continent** remains under monster control.

SECTION 16: INSTITUTIONS OF THE LAND

16.1 The Seven Recognized Churches

The Order of the Dawn (Aloria -- Light & Life) is the most politically powerful church. Its temples exist in all settlements, with the main temple in Weaveheart. Its clergy are healers, midwives, protectors, and paladins who run hospices, tend the sick, and stand as a shining beacon of hope.

The Guild of the Spark (Thalkis -- Forge & Arcana) combines church with craft guild. Its temples are workshops, forges, and arcane libraries. The main temple is in Emberforge, with strong ties to the city's smithing traditions. Clergy are smith-priests, enchanters, and artificers.

The Circle of the Wild (Kaelthor -- Nature & Tempest) is a loose affiliation of druids, rangers, and weather-watchers with no centralized hierarchy. Its most important sites are ancient groves, sacred mountains, and wild places. The world itself is considered the only true temple.

The Order of the Scales (Aurelius -- Wisdom & Justice) operates temples that double as libraries, courts, and academies. The main temple is in Weaveheart. Clergy are judges, scholars, diplomats, and lawkeepers who preserve pre-invasion knowledge and advise rulers on legal matters.

The Order of the Currency (Crassian -- Wealth & Fortune) has temples that double as banks and marketplaces. The main temple is in Drakhaven, with a strong presence in all capitals. Clergy are traders, moneylenders, and advisors on risky ventures, connected to the Mint and major trade guilds.

The Vigil of the Dusk (Vesper -- Peace & Twilight) maintains a quiet, contemplative presence. Its temples are sanctuaries of peace. The main temple is in Weaveheart. Clergy are diplomats, hospice workers, gatekeepers, and mediators.

The Pack of Tyra (Tyra -- Hunt & Nature) is the most decentralized of the recognized churches. It is organized into loose hunting bands called "packs," with no single headquarters. The seasonal Great Hunt convenes at a rotating frontier location. Clergy are hunters, survivalists, game wardens, and trappers.

16.2 The First Alliance

The **First Alliance** was the unprecedented military and political alliance formed after the three capitals were established. It defeated three of the Five Monster Generals and continues to oversee the reconquering effort. Its membership includes all recovered settlements, knightly orders, and major guilds.

16.3 The Council Accord & Ecumenical Council

The **Council Accord** is the governing body of the three capitals, the highest authority in mortal civilization, coordinating military strategy, resource allocation, and territorial expansion. The **Ecumenical Council** represents the seven recognized churches, mediating disputes, coordinating festivals, and presenting a unified religious front.

16.4 House Thormvuld

House Thormvuld is a dwarven arcane engineering dynasty and the most prominent magical item producer on the continent. Originating from the northeast mining region, the family recently built the floating estate **Seidga'ard** and was subject to a high-profile heist. The house is ruthless and authoritarian, and it is currently hunting the thieves. **Lord Keylor Thormvuld** is the patriarch.

16.5 The Venom-Weavers

The **Venom-Weavers** are a prolific assassin guild specializing in poisons and knife combat. They operate in the shadows of major settlements and throughout the frontier, not aligned with any faction. They serve whoever pays and are one of the most feared and respected underworld organizations. The guild is led by **Rhael** and organized into a hierarchy of skill and trust.

16.6 The Dark Alliance

The **Dark Alliance** is a newly formed political alliance between the **Drow of the Underdark** and the **Shadow Elves of the Shadowfell** -- two races that have historically been isolated and distrusted. Knowledge of this alliance is only recently spreading.

SECTION 17: PLACES OF NOTE

17.1 The Six Fallen Capitals

Drakhaven, the former Human capital, was the largest and most advanced pre-invasion city on the continent. Its people self-appointed it the "capital of Kythoria." Located at the center of the continent, it was the seat of the Drakh Ix'thar and the High Septon. It has been partially reclaimed; the guild headquarters and the High Septon have been restored.

Elyndor, the former Elven capital, was an ancient forest city of arcane knowledge that blended seamlessly with the natural landscape around a sacred grove. It fell to the monster invasion, and its ruins remain in monster-held territory.

Kazadur, the former Dwarven capital in the northeast, was a mountain-forge city with the greatest mines on the continent. Before the fall, the dwarven king sealed the deep halls and collapsed the tunnels. The mines have been partially reclaimed, but the sealed halls remain undiscovered. Survivors' blueprints and knowledge led to the establishment of Emberforge.

Hearthglen, the former Halfling capital, was the economic heart of the continent, home to the royal mint. The monster army annihilated it -- fields salted, granaries looted, every building burned. The valley remains scarred, and small halfling communities have re-established elsewhere.

Everquill, the former Gnome capital, was the paper capital of law, records, and maps. When the city fell, gnome archivists fled carrying the treaties, laws, maps, and histories of all six kingdoms. Much of what the Last Stand knows about the pre-invasion era was carried from Everquill in those fleeing carts. The ruins stand in monster-held territory, and the Great Archive's lower vaults may have survived.

Stonefist, the former Half-Orc capital, was a rugged fortress of proud warriors. Its ruins remain in monster-held territory, and Half-Orc survivors carried their martial traditions to the First Alliance.

17.2 Living Settlements

Stonefall is a practical frontier town on the edge of Last Stand territory. Built of timber and stone, with a population of a few dozen, it is the last real settlement before the wilderness. It serves as a trading post for frontier goods and a resting point for expeditions heading into monster territory. It features a half-finished wall, a tavern, a market square, a shrine to Aurelius, and a blacksmith.

The **Southeastern Port** is a major sea trade hub, heavily fortified, coastal, and highly defensible. It is one of the main maritime commerce centers.

The **Eastern Port** is an additional sea connection on the eastern coast, serving as a fishing, trade, and travel hub.

17.3 The High Septon

The **High Septon** is the central temple of Aurelius, located in Drakhaven. It is here that paladins swear their oaths before Aurelius, in a solemn ceremony that marks the culmination of years of training and preparation.

SECTION 18: THE PRESENT DAY

18.1 The Heist on Seidga'ard

A coordinated two-party group infiltrated House Thormvuld's floating estate. One party gathered intelligence disguised as catering staff, while a second party entered under diplomatic cover as ambassadors of the Dark Alliance. Crystals, schematics, and prototype devices were reportedly stolen. House Thormvuld claims nothing too valuable was taken, but they are actively hunting the perpetrators. Details remain murky; public knowledge is based on rumors and gossip.

18.2 The Dark Alliance Emergence

The Drow and Shadow Elves have formed a new political alliance. Knowledge of this alliance is only recently spreading, and its implications for the surface world remain to be seen.

18.3 State of the Reconquering

Three-quarters of the continent has been reclaimed. Population numbers are back to approximately 60% of pre-invasion values. The economy is functional, food growth is stable, and the political situation is balanced. Strong cooperation exists between the races. The hardest contest remains on the north and north-west, but the reconquering endures.

SECTION 19: WHAT THE PEOPLE SAY

19.1 Proverbs & Sayings

"**Divided we fight but united we stand**" -- This is the core ethos of the Last Stand, a saying that echoes in every settlement, every tavern, every war council. It is the creed of a people who learned, through centuries of suffering, that survival depends on unity.

"**The world is the only true temple**" -- A teaching of the Circle of the Wild, reminding the faithful that the divine is not confined to walls of stone, but is present in every forest, every mountain, every storm.

"**A city's strength is measured by its contributions to the reconquering**" -- A practical proverb that reflects the merit-based values of Kythorian society, where deeds matter more than birth.

19.2 Things Everyone Knows

Every Kythorian knows that the humans of Drakhaven called their city the "capital of Kythoria" -- a boast the other races accepted with a smirk, making light fun of human self-importance.

Every Kythorian knows that **halflings are the continent's perfect accountants** -- intelligent, organized, rigorous, and the backbone of the continental economy.

Every Kythorian knows that **Emberforge weapons are the finest available** -- forged in geothermal fires that no surface forge can match.

Every Kythorian knows that the **magical barrier has held for two centuries**; few people alive remember the world without it.

Every Kythorian knows that the **Day of Silence** is the only day when no one works and no magic is cast -- a day of quiet reflection honoring the dead.

Every Kythorian knows that the **Drakh Ix'thar guild predates the monster invasion**, a living link to the world that was.

Every Kythorian knows that approximately **70% of pre-invasion knowledge has been lost** -- a tragedy that drives the work of scholars, adventurers, and historians across the continent.

Every Kythorian knows that **Crassian's Dust Circle** earned its name honestly: the great clouds of dust raised by caravans traversing the ancient trade route were visible for miles, a sign of commerce and connection between the kingdoms of old.

This document represents the boundary of what an average, educated citizen of Kythoria would know about their world at the start of the campaign. The knowledge beyond this boundary is known only by a few, and are not yet the stuff of common knowledge.